

Editorial Style Guidance

Office of Communications, Penn State Eberly College of Science

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Penn State

Penn State, not *PSU*, *Penn State University*, or *The Pennsylvania State University*.

Eberly College of Science

Penn State Eberly College of Science, not *ECoS* or *College of Science*; also, *the college* (lowercase) when used with the unofficial name of the college, or when used alone, on subsequent mention.

University Park

Penn State University Park (initial mention); University Park campus (subsequent mentions); events should be described as being on the Penn State University Park campus.

Academic and Administrative Titles

Titles are capitalized when they immediately precede names and are used as part of the names (*Dean Tracy Langkilde*; *Professor Doug Cavener*), lowercased if they follow names or are used to help describe or identify people further (*Tracy Langkilde*, *professor of biology*; *well-known professor of biology Tracy Langkilde*).

If the person holds a named professorship or chair, such as an endowed professorship, capitalize the title whether it precedes or follows the name (*Squire Booker*, *Evan Pugh University Professor of Chemistry*; *Evan Pugh University Professor of Chemistry Squire Booker*; *Stephen Benkovic*, *Holder of the Eberly Family Chair in Chemistry*).

Also: *instructor in*, not *instructor of*; *professor emeritus*, not *emeritus professor*; *professor of*, not *professor in*—but *professorship in*; *research associate in*, not *research associate of*.

When the title includes the specific name of an academic or administrative unit, the name of the unit is capitalized (*Sarah Shandera*, *director of the Institute for Gravitation and the Cosmos*).

Dr.

"Dr." should only be used, on first reference, preceding the name of a person with a medical degree. Do not use "Dr." on second reference. "Dr." may be used in a direct quote.

Room Numbers and Building Names

Use the room number and building name (*100 Thomas Building* on first mention; *100 Thomas* on subsequent mention); if a building name is used without a room number, use the word *Building*, *Lab*, or the equivalent on every reference, and capitalize (*Thomas Building*; *Davey Lab*).

Named Spaces

On first mention, use the full, proper name of spaces on campus that have been named for University benefactors and leaders.

- Berg Auditorium (100 Huck Life Sciences Building)
- Dr. Jack & Pauline Dickstein Collaborative Learning Center (lower-level study space in Ritenour Building)
- HUB-Robeson Center ("the HUB")
- Nicholas and Gelsa Pelick Courtyard (the courtyard outside Chemistry building)
- Verne M. Willaman Gateway to the Sciences ("the Bridge")

Academic Degrees

Spelling out degrees helps with readability (*He earned a bachelor of science degree in physics; she earned a bachelor's degree in chemistry*).

Spelled out: associate degree; baccalaureate degree, bachelor's degree; master's degree; doctoral degree, doctorate; bachelor of arts, master of science, doctor of philosophy.

When abbreviating degrees, use periods without spaces: B.A.; M.S.; Ph.D.; M.B.A.; M.D., etc. (**plurals:** B.A.'s; M.A.'s; Ph.D.'s, etc.).

Academic Programs, Majors, Fields of Study

Cap the names of majors or minors when used as specific programs offered at Penn State, but do not cap the words major, minor, option, or program, only the program name if appropriate (*He majored in Astronomy and Astrophysics at Penn State; the college offers the Biochemistry and Molecular Biology major; the Mathematics program has undergone changes, including to the Actuarial Mathematics option*).

When referring to specific degree programs at Penn State, capitalize the program name but not the degree (*The college offers a master of professional studies degree program in Forensic Science; John Smith is a graduate of the master of applied statistics degree program in Statistics*).

Alumni and Graduation Years

Generally, the year should be written out in text (*Smith is a 2024 graduate in statistics; Smith graduated in 2024 with a master's degree in statistics*) or when referencing a person's class year (*John Smith is part of the Class of 2024*).

Semesters

Lowercased (*spring semester, fall semester*).

Department Names

Capitalize when used as formal name: *Department of Chemistry*; lowercase as informal name: *the chemistry department, the department*.

Date/Time

Date: spell out the month, and don't use an ordinal (*October 6*, not *Oct. 6th*).

Time: include the zeroes where appropriate, follow with a space, and include *a.m.* and *p.m.* (lowercased, with periods); noon and midnight are exceptions (don't use *12:00 a.m.* or *12:00 p.m.*).

Ranges: should be written with an en dash, no space on either side (*8:00 a.m.–5:00 p.m.*); when using *from* or *between*, write out *to* or *and* instead of using an en dash (*from noon to 1:00 p.m.; between noon and 1:00 p.m.*).

Time zone: if a time zone is included, it should be set in parentheses: (EDT).

Bulleted/Numbered Lists

A vertical list is best introduced by a grammatically complete sentence, followed by a colon.

Emphasis

Use italics for emphasis only as an occasional adjunct to efficient sentence structure. Overused, italics quickly lose their force. Seldom should as much as a sentence be italicized for emphasis, and never a whole passage.

Occasionally, boldface or underscore (also called underlining) is used for emphasis. In formal prose, especially in print, italics are usually more appropriate.

Capitalizing an entire word or phrase for emphasis is rarely appropriate in formal prose.

See the *Chicago Manual of Style*, Chapter 7, section ["Emphasis," 7.50–7.52](#), for more information.

End Punctuation

If it's a complete sentence, it needs end punctuation (period, etc.); if incomplete, generally omit the end punctuation.

Ampersand

Do not substitute an ampersand (&) for the word *and*.

Titles of Works

Titles mentioned or cited in text or notes are usually capitalized headline-style (see [8.159: Principles of headline-style capitalization](#) in the *Chicago Manual of Style*).

Titles of books and periodicals are italicized; titles of articles, chapters, and other shorter works are set in roman and enclosed in quotation marks (see [8.177: Articles, stories, chapters, and so on](#)).

For treatment of book series and editions, see [8.176](#); for pamphlets and forms, see [8.186–87](#); for movies, television, radio, and podcasts, see [8.189](#); for websites and blogs, see [8.191–92](#).

Subheads

The *Chicago Manual of Style* prefers headline-style capitalization for subheads (see [8.159](#)), with no period added at the end.

Link Text

Avoid using phrases like “click here” (see ["Writing Meaningful Link Text" on the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines website](#)).

Acronyms

A few universally recognized abbreviations are required in some circumstances. Some others are acceptable, depending on the context. But in general, avoid alphabet soup. Do not use abbreviations or acronyms that the reader would not quickly recognize.

[A general rule from the *Chicago Manual of Style*](#) is to limit the use of abbreviations to terms that occur frequently enough to warrant abbreviation—roughly five times or more within a given material. Such an abbreviation should not be offered only once, never to be used again, except as an alternative form that may be better known to some readers.